

“In the long run, religion can’t solve basic issues like *roti, kapda, makaan*”

The enthusiasm for the Ram temple inauguration may not be uniform across India, but the BJP stands to gain electorally. For now, thanks to the way the BJP has managed the public imagination, the Hindu identity, united by the euphoria over the Ram temple, will prevail. And that’s the reason the Opposition’s decision to decline the invite to the Ram temple consecration may go against them electorally. No political party in India can stay away from religion anymore. India has moved on from the secularism envisioned in the Constitution. It will be very difficult to revert to the original idea of secularism in the next few decades. Even the minorities in India seem to have accepted this position as they don’t want to get involved in a confrontation that can lead to amplification such as physical violence. But the excitement over the temple may not be sustainable in the long run as religion can’t solve the basic issues of roti, kapda, makaan.

NARENDER KUMAR

Chairperson, Centre for Political Studies, Jawaharlal Nehru University



“The participation of the PM is the arrival of a triumphalist state”

TANWEER FAZAL

Professor, Dept of Sociology, University of Hyderabad

THE CONSTRUCTION OF THE RAM temple is a continuation of the politics of polarisation the BJP and Sangh Parivar began in the 1980s. In that sense, the build-up around the inauguration replicates the campaign from its earlier phase. However, there is a certain uniqueness to it. Since the temple is being built on the site where the mosque was demolished, the participation of the PM announces the arrival of an unapologetically triumphalist state. We are now flooded with media narratives celebrating the ‘martyrdom’ of the kar sevaks who demolished the mosque, an act earlier termed a ‘national shame’ by none other than former BJP prime minister A.B. Vajpayee. The social base of Hindutva is far more expansive than what it was in the past. Over the years, it has successfully roped in sections of Dalits, OBCs and MBCs in its idea of grand unity against the ‘other’.

“The Ram temple has blurred caste fault lines, at least for the time being”

BIKRAM KESHARI MISHRA

Professor, Dept of Sociology, Ravenshaw University, Bhubaneswar

POLITICAL OVERTONES notwithstanding, the Ram temple has blurred caste fault lines, at least for the time being. It’s one occasion that seems to have solidified the Hindu fraternity. However, this is not to be seen as resilience against any other community. This is not what one would call a Hindu resurgence. Resurgence comes when the struggle for a sociopolitical goal is going on. But nothing of the sort has happened here, so there is no reason to assume that there is a Hindu resurgence. The Ram temple construction in India can also be visualised in this light, where no political party is eager to let go of the benefit of identity politics. Only the rallying point differs.



Contributed by Kaushik Deka, Anilesh S. Mahajan, Rohit Parihar and Arkamoy Datta Majumdar